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Bernard Lonergan as Interpreter of Aquinas: A Complex Relation

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ABSTRACT: *The essay proposes a fourfold explanatory schema of the complex relation between the work of Bernard Lonergan and Thomas Aquinas. The first moment of the schema is understood to be the development by Lonergan of a basic interpretive stance towards Aquinas. This basic stance is verified in the work of recent Thomas scholars. Each subsequent moment in the schema is linked by a relation of genetic emergence to the moment or moments that precede it. The author then proposes new directions opened up in Thomist studies by Lonergan's achievement.*

KEY WORDS: *Aquinas, St. Thomas (1225-1274); Aristotilism; Coreth, Emerich (1919-2006); Dialectic; Grace; History; Intellection; Kant, Immanuel (1724-1804); Knowledge; Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Metaphysics; Rhetoric; Self-Understanding; Spirituality; Theology as science; Theology; Thomism; Thomistic studies; Transcendental Method; Trivium; Turn to the Subject.*

RESUMO: *O presente artigo propõe um esquema explicativo em quatro momentos acerca da complexa relação existente entre Bernard Lonergan e o pensamento de S. Tomás de Aquino. O primeiro momento do esquema refere-se ao desenvolvimento por Lonergan do seu posicionamento de intérprete em relação à obra de S. Tomás. Este posicionamento é, depois, cuidadosamente verificado no contributo de alguns dos intérpretes mais recentes do pensamento de S. Tomás de Aquino. Cada momento subsequente no esquema está relacionado mediante uma relação de emergência genética com o momento ou momentos que o precedem. Desse modo, finalmente, o artigo propõe, em atenção ao sucesso do empreendimento de Bernard Lonergan, um conjunto de novas direcções para os estudos do pensamento tomista.*

PALAVRAS-CHAVE: *Aquino, S. Tomás de (1225-1274); Aristotelismo; Auto-Compreensão; Conhecimento; Coreth, Emerich (1919-2006); Dialéctica; Espiritualidade; Estudos tomísticos; Graça; História; Intelecção; Kant, Immanuel (1724-1804); Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Metafísica; Método transcendental; Retórica; Teologia como Ciência; Teologia; Tomismo; Trivium; Viragem para o Sujeito.*

1. Introduction

In this essay, I propose a framework for understanding the complex relationship between the work of Bernard Lonergan and that of Thomas Aquinas.

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Few of Lonergan's second and third (and perhaps by now fourth!) generation students understand the connection between the two thinkers. In addition, some contemporary Thomists are leery of Lonergan's starting point in cognitive theory, preferring instead to make of Thomas' starting point in metaphysics a kind of litmus test of Thomist orthodoxy.

I know, as a student of both Thomas and Lonergan, that my reading of Thomas takes for granted that Lonergan has settled once and for all some key issues in the interpretation of Aquinas' theology; I do not believe that Lonergan's interpretation constitutes a betrayal of Thomas' project. I write this essay in the hopes of bringing into clearer focus Lonergan's Thomism, as well as clearing up misunderstandings of Lonergan's interpretation of Aquinas.

I do not pretend to discuss all the possible ways of relating Lonergan and Aquinas; nor do I make an exhaustive treatment of the details of Lonergan's vast corpus of Thomist studies. What I propose instead is a kind of explanatory schema for understanding Lonergan as an interpreter of Aquinas, one that refutes accusations of distortion and bias, and suggests why Lonergan's reading of Aquinas is so fruitful. Some of this material, I am sure, will be "old news" to those who belong to an earlier generation of Lonergan scholars; I hope that the schema I propose, along with some developments I articulate at the end of the paper, will nevertheless be of interest to everyone.

2. The Basic Lineaments of the Story

The basic outline of how Lonergan came to the study of Aquinas has been ably narrated by Lonergan himself in "Insight Revisited", and supplemented by Fred Crowe in the prefaces to both *Grace and Freedom* and *Verbum* in the Collected Works editions of these volumes. I will rehearse it quickly here by way of providing an orientation to the material, and complete it with a rapid summary of Lonergan's self-named apprenticeship to Aquinas, and his efforts to promote a renewed Thomism.

Lonergan's philosophical training at Heythrop College, as both he and Crowe tell us, was not Thomist but Suarezian in its orientation.¹ At this time, Lonergan, though interested in philosophy, was "extremely critical of the key position accorded universal concepts" in the philosophy taught at Heythrop, and thought of himself as a nominalist.² It was during this time that he encountered Newman's work on assent: "My fundamental mentor and guide has been John Henry Newman's *Grammar of Assent*. I read that in my third

¹ "Insight Revisited." In: Bernard LONERGAN – *A Second Collection: Papers*. Edited by William F. J. Ryan; Bernard J. Tyrrell. Toronto: Published by University of Toronto Press for Lonergan Research Institute of Regis College, 1996, p. 263.

² Ibid.

year philosophy (at least the analytic parts) about five times and found solutions for my problems. I was not at all satisfied with the philosophy that was being taught and found Newman's presentation to be something that fitted in with the way I knew things. It was from that kernel that I went on to different authors."³

When he was leaving Heythrop to proceed to his three years of high school teaching at Loyola in Montreal, he was invited to consider seriously taking up the study of philosophy or theology as a service to the Society of Jesus. When he raised the objection that his nominalism would make him ineligible to teach in the seminaries of the Society of Jesus – nominalism being precisely the denial of universals, and therefore considered by the dominant Catholic philosophy of the day a lapse into skepticism and a modernist error – he was told “no one remains a nominalist very long.”⁴

This reply, as Lonergan himself admitted, was to prove prophetic. During his regency at Loyola College in Montreal, he discovered J. A. Stewart's *Plato's Doctrine of Ideas*, which led him to read Plato's early dialogues. Just as Augustine's therapeutic encounter with Platonism liberated him from his materialism, so Lonergan's encounter with Plato as a “methodologist” freed him to consider the operations of human understanding, though he was not able to articulate this to himself until later.⁵ Towards the end of his regency, Lonergan picked up the earlier works of Saint Augustine, and in his own words “found [Augustine] to be psychologically exact.”⁶

Before beginning his theological studies at the Collège de l'Immaculée Conception in Montreal, Lonergan began to “study the *Summa* at first hand and began to suspect that St. Thomas was not nearly as bad as he is painted.”⁷ This was 1933, and that summer during his vacation with other Jesuits on Wolfe Island near Kingston, Ontario, Canada, Lonergan produced a 25,000 word essay on the act of faith to test out his emerging synthesis of the issues. Fragments of the essay can be found in the archives of the Lonergan Research Institute.⁸ According to Fred Crowe, it may also be during this time that Lonergan read Peter Hoenen's *Gregorianum* essay on what intellect abstracts from the phantasm. Two months into his studies in Montreal, Lonergan was

³ Bernard LONERGAN – “Reality, Myth, Symbol.” In: Alan M. OLSON (ed.) – *Myth, Symbol, and Reality*. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1980, pp. 32-33.

⁴ Bernard Lonergan to Fr. Henry Keane, Provincial Superior of Upper Canada, January 22, 1935, page 3. All quotations from Lonergan's correspondence in this essay are made with permission of the Trustees of the Lonergan Estate.

⁵ “Insight Revisited”, cit., pp. 264-5.

⁶ Lonergan to Henry Keane, cit., p. 3.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ See the reference and description of the essay in Michael Shield's introduction to his translation of Lonergan's “Analysis Fidei” in *Method: a Journal of Lonergan Studies*, Fall 2002.

transferred to Rome to finish his basic theology. It was during this time that he encountered – in his own words, by osmosis – the thought of Maréchal, which taught him “to speak of human knowledge as not intuitive but discursive with the decisive component in judgment.”⁹ This understanding cohered with Lonergan’s reading of Augustine on *veritas*, and with what he was taught in Christology about the real distinction between essence and existence, which alone could make sense of the hypostatic union.¹⁰ One and a half years into his basic theology studies, in January 1935, Lonergan was already able to write with some confidence to his provincial superior: “I can give you my present position in a few words. It is definite, definitive, and something of a problem. The current interpretation of St. Thomas is a consistent misinterpretation... I can prove out of St. Thomas himself that the current interpretation is absolutely wrong.”¹¹

After his final year of spiritual formation at Amiens in France, Lonergan was slated to begin a doctorate in philosophy at the Gregorian University in the fall of 1938. At the last minute, he was told to switch from philosophy to theology, with the result that, as Fred Crowe writes “...he arrived in Rome somewhat at a loss for a dissertation topic, and so readily accepted a suggestion of Professor Charles Boyer that he study a knotty question of divine grace in the writings of St. Thomas.”¹²

The rest of the story of Lonergan’s relationship to Aquinas is easy to trace from Lonergan’s writings. Following upon the work on his dissertation on *gratia operans* in Aquinas, Lonergan published the series of *Theological Studies* articles that would become *Verbum*; it is in these articles that he gave a full articulation to what he had understood about Aquinas as the result of his personal development between 1930 and 1935. During his time of teaching theology in Montreal, Rome and Toronto, Lonergan published several sets of course notes in which he interpreted and developed Thomas’ theological positions. He also used several book reviews submitted during this period as opportunities to develop his interpretation of Thomas. A number of them were gathered in *Collection*.¹³ That volume, first published in 1967, also gathers papers on various questions of Thomist interest.¹⁴ Of particular interest are the lectures “The Future of Thomism,” first given in Pittsburgh in 1968 and

⁹ “Insight Revisited,” cit., p. 265.

¹⁰ Ibid.

¹¹ Letter to Henry Keane, cit., p. 4.

¹² Frederick CROWE – “Editor’s Preface.” In: Bernard LONERGAN – *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*. Collected works of Bernard Lonergan; vol. 2. Edited by Frederick E. Crowe; Robert M. Doran. Toronto; Buffalo: University of Toronto Press for Lonergan Research Institute, 1997, p. ix.

¹³ Cf. “On God and Secondary Causes”, and especially “Theology and Understanding.”

¹⁴ Cf. “The Natural Desire to See God,” and “Isomorphism of Thomist and Scientific Thought.”

then published in *Second Collection* in 1974, and “Aquinas Today: Tradition and Innovation” given at the University of Chicago in 1974 and subsequently published in *A Third Collection* in 1985.

Such is the basic narrative of Lonergan’s relationship to Aquinas. What I propose to do in what follows is move from this descriptive account to a more explanatory grasp of Lonergan’s evolving relation to Aquinas. I shall posit that Lonergan’s relation to Aquinas is fourfold, or has four related moments. These moments are roughly chronological, but their intelligible connection is one of genetic emergence.

3. An Explanatory Account in Four Moments

3.1. The First Moment

The first moment in our explanatory account of Lonergan’s relation to Aquinas roughly corresponds to the writing of *Gratia Operans* and *Verbum*, though as we shall see, it is rooted in developments that precede them both.

3.1.1. Grace and Freedom

Lonergan writes, in the historical introduction to *Gratia Operans*, that his inquiry is “confined to the history of theological speculation...”¹⁵ Already in this text we see evidence of Lonergan’s usual practice in historical analysis: the close reading of texts in light of their methodological elements, noticing the genetic and dialectical relations between texts, “what was going forward” in intellectual history. Pages 14 and 15 of *Grace and Freedom* contain his standard account of the emergence of theory from common sense. We often note Lonergan’s learning from Maréchal, but *Gratia Operans* reveals a Lonergan who has appropriated the work of historians of the *ressourcement* movement: Dom Odon Lottin, Marie-Dominique Chenu, Artur Landgraf, Johann Schupp and Herbert Doms. We also see the seeds of key notions that will bear fruit later in Lonergan’s work, for example the notion of redemption as God’s initiating of a new line of development in history, here termed “a new continuity in justice.”¹⁶

What is perhaps most significant for our purposes here, however, is Lonergan’s grasp of the significance of the emergence of the theorem of the supernatural, and its effects in a kind of “Copernican revolution” that will only be

¹⁵ Bernard LONERGAN – *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St Thomas Aquinas*. Collected works of Bernard Lonergan; vol. 1. Edited by Frederick E. Crowe; Robert M. Doran. Toronto; Buffalo: Published for Lonergan Research Institute of Regis College, Toronto, by University of Toronto Press, 2000, p. 160.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, pp. 57-58.

mastered by “the genius of St. Thomas Aquinas.”¹⁷ One of Lonergan’s key discoveries here is how the theorem of the supernatural grounds Aquinas’ use of Aristotle. The Lonergan of *Grace and Freedom* grasps that Aquinas is first and foremost a theologian who is trying to understand concrete theological events of grace. He grasps this *precisely because* he understands the methodological role of metaphysics and Aristotelian psychology within the analogy that obtains between natural and supernatural realities. Lonergan knows that Aquinas is speaking of grace as a real and concrete event in a human life, and he can relegate the methodological apparatus to its proper role within Aquinas’ theological schema. This may be of no great significance to us after the publication of *Method in Theology*, but in the 1940’s, such a position could – and did – cut through a morass of pseudo-problems in the interpretation of Aquinas, and did so in a revolutionary way. All we have to do to get a sense of the radical nature of Lonergan’s proposal is recall the theological and ecclesial controversy that greeted Henri de Lubac’s initial publication of his studies on the mystery of the supernatural in 1947. It was not until 1965, with the publication of his second volume on the subject, that de Lubac would consider himself fully vindicated.

3.1.2. *Verbum*

The developmental arc that reaches its goal in the *Verbum* studies begins with Lonergan’s dissatisfaction with the conceptualism of his philosophy training at Heythrop, and proceeds through his reading of Newman, Plato, Augustine and Aquinas prior to theology. It reaches a significant station in the essay on the act of faith sent to Fr. Henry Smeaton and alluded to in the letter to Fr. Keane, the Jesuit provincial superior, in 1935. It is worth turning again to this letter, to hear Lonergan explaining himself:

The current interpretation of St. Thomas is a consistent misinterpretation... I can prove out of St. Thomas himself that the current interpretation is absolutely wrong. Not only can I prove it, but the issue has already been raised decisively though not completely or altogether satisfactorily by Fr. Marechal [*sic*] whose views reign in our house at Louvain but are somewhat frowned upon here... [What] the current Thomists call intellectual knowledge is really sense knowledge; of intellectual knowledge they have nothing to say; intellectual knowledge is, for example, the “seeing the nexus” between subject and predicate in a universal judgment: this seeing a nexus is an operation they never explain.¹⁸

This break with the surrounding conceptualism and intuitivism gave Lonergan the lever to grasp Augustine’s and Thomas’ account of *intelligere*. In *Verbum* he understands Thomas’ challenge to have been relating the Augustinian *mens* – a phenomenological reflection on the psychology of the life of

¹⁷ Ibid., pp. 15-19.

¹⁸ Letter to Fr. Keane, cit., p. 4.

the soul – to the Aristotelian *anima* – a set of metaphysical terms and relations that ground an account of the soul that has a life before God. The method Lonergan chooses in the *Verbum* studies makes use of literary and historical instruments, but also posits a necessary moment of verification in one's own operations of what Augustine and Aquinas *meant*. This is rooted in the conviction that Aquinas and Aristotle knew in themselves the operations they were talking about: "Aquinas explicitly appealed to inner experience and... Aristotle's account of intelligence... has too uncanny an accuracy to be possible without the greatest introspective skill.... [But] they did not thematize their use [of inner experience]." ¹⁹ Lonergan's grasp of the fundamental importance of Augustinian and Thomist *intelligere* governs his fruitful resolution of a whole series of interpretive issues in Aquinas' account of *verbum*, and grounds his turn away from a metaphysical starting point to a starting point in the psychological content – the operations themselves – of Thomas' theory of intellect. Along the way, Lonergan can reinforce the strictly theological reading of Aquinas begun in *Grace and Freedom*; give a much more fruitful account of Thomas' sublation of Aristotle in light of Augustinian insights; show how satisfying Thomas' analogical explication of *emanatio intelligibilis* in the Trinity really is; and much more.

3.1.3. An Initial description of the first moment: Developing an upper blade

The Lonergan Research Institute archives in Toronto have copies of two letters, one dated April 21, 1963, and the other dated January 31, 1965. Both of these letters are addressed to Fred Crowe, and allude to Lonergan's plans for the publication of *Grace and Freedom* and *Verbum*. In the 1963 letter, it is clear that Lonergan plans to have both studies published as one volume: he even calls the proposed book "Two Thomist Studies." In the 1965 letter, he realizes that it may not be possible to publish the two studies together, and is unhappy with this fact: "I have my reasons," he writes, "for wanting them together, but though I see the moon I do not reach for it." ²⁰

I would like to propose, by way of summary, one possible reason for Lonergan's desire to publish these two texts together. Each study contains a basic insight into Aquinas' theology. The two insights that constitute this first moment in the relation of Lonergan to Aquinas are the discovery of the significance of the theorem of the supernatural in *Grace and Freedom* and the bringing to full expression of Lonergan's grasp of the Thomist *intelligere* in the *Verbum* studies. Taken together, these two insights articulate a fundamental interpretive stance which Lonergan will consistently take before the

¹⁹ *Verbum*, op. cit., pp. 5-6.

²⁰ Letter to Frederick Crowe, January 31, 1965, p. 1.

text of Aquinas. This basic interpretive stance is an upper blade that enables Lonergan to advert to the whole range of methods Aquinas deploys in his practice of theology.

Before we can give a fuller articulation of this interpretive stance, we need to explore recent developments in Aquinas research that confirm Lonergan's rediscovery of Aquinas as primarily a theologian. Further developments verify and amplify Lonergan's understanding of the relation between nature and supernature in Aquinas' theology, particularly as this relation governs methodology. Our verification will proceed in five steps.

3.1.4. Verification I: The primacy of theology in Aquinas

Gerald McCool, in his study of fortunes of Thomism in the twentieth century, suggests that the movement to revive interest in Thomas, rooted in Leo XIII's encyclical *Aeterni Patris*, contained the seeds of its own destruction. Leo had hoped that the post-Cartesian plurality of methods that had introduced confusion in the Church's seminaries could be remedied by a return to genuine Thomism. "At the same time," writes McCool, "a purified and reinvigorated Thomism should develop its capacity to integrate human knowledge through its dialogue with contemporary science, philosophy, and culture."²¹ The challenge of *Aeterni Patris* was first taken up by the neo-Thomist movement, which pursued the unified Thomism of the encyclical. In the years between 1930-1950, however, the broad movement of theologians known as the *ressourcement* produced a veritable deluge of interpretive and historical studies of Aquinas. These studies, which were at the source of the so-called *nouvelle théologie*, challenged the assumption that Thomas represented the crystallization of a unified medieval school of thought.²² The *ressourcement* scholars also advocated a return to Thomas as a *theologian*, as opposed to the neo-Thomist portrait of Aquinas as a philosopher.

The current resurgence of interest in the thought of Aquinas owes much to the *ressourcement*. Otto Hermann Pesch traces four crucial stages in the path that led to the current image of Thomas: (1) the rediscovery of the "Christian philosopher" who is not simply reducible to his Aristotelianism, but who articulates a unique philosophy anchored in the viewpoint of faith (one thinks here of the work of Gilson and Pieper in particular); (2) the growing interest in Thomas' *theology*, expressed in textual and historical studies such as those of the *ressourcement* (in the teaching of the Dominicans at le Saulchoir, and of the Jesuits at Fourvière); (3) the discovery, in Christian theology in

²¹ Gerald A. McCool – *From Unity to Pluralism: the Internal Evolution of Thomism*. New York: Fordham University Press, 1989, p. 1.

²² Ibid., pp. 208-10.

general, of the category of *history*, and the rediscovery in Thomas of his *orientation towards salvation history* and his concern for the *oikonomia* revealed in Scripture (this is the ongoing conversation begun by Chenu's discussion of the structure of the *Summa Theologiae*); (4) the development of an *ecumenical interest* in the teaching of Thomas, beginning with such theologians as Karl Barth.²³

This interest in retrieving Thomas as a theologian rooted in Scripture and the *oikonomia* has generated three convergent lines of development: first, the growing understanding of Thomas' notion of theology as *sacra doctrina*; second, the appreciation of the historical and dynamic nature of his thought; and finally, the recent emphasis on Thomas as a spiritual theologian.

3.1.5. Verification II: Aquinas' theology as a *sacra doctrina*

Thomas' way of doing theology is alien to ours. His understanding of sacred science, writes Pesch, holds together God's speaking of a word in history and human efforts to understand this speech. God's action becomes our wisdom.²⁴ As Jean-Pierre Torrell explains in greater detail, for Aquinas *sacra doctrina* is the whole complex of actions by means of which Christian truth comes to us: God's own teaching activity in revelation, the living tradition (including liturgical life), the activity of preachers and catechists, and finally theological research and teaching.²⁵

Eugene Rogers concurs with this interpretation of the notion of *sacra doctrina* in Thomas. He adds an important insight into Thomas' notion of *sacra doctrina* by highlighting the importance of *scientia* to Thomas' project: "if we see in sacred-doctrine-as-*scientia* primarily an attempt, from outside theology, to relate faith and reason, or theology and philosophy, then we will misunderstand it... Thomas is working within sacred doctrine to specify a relation internal to it..."²⁶ Thomas' Aristotelianism is not outside *sacra doctrina*, but within it and at the service of his Christocentrism. He saw clearly that Aristotle provided him with the most rigorous scientific method; this method, developed in theology, led him to find his first principles in Scripture, and at the centre of Scripture was the person of Christ. Rogers suggests that the relation is such that "the more Aristotelian *sacra doctrina* is, the more scriptural

²³ Otto Hermann PESCH – *Thomas d'Aquin: Grandeur et limites de la théologie médiévale*. Paris: Éditions du Cerf, 1994, pp. 38-42.

²⁴ PESCH – op. cit., p. 54.

²⁵ Jean-Pierre TORRELL – *Saint Thomas d'Aquin, maître spirituel*. Fribourg: Éditions Universitaires de Fribourg, 1996, p. 2.

²⁶ Eugene ROGERS – *Thomas Aquinas and Karl Barth: Sacred Doctrine and the Natural Knowledge of God*. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1995, pp. 19-20.

it is," which presupposes that "the more Aristotelian it is, the more christoform it is."²⁷

What emerges from these studies is a clearer understanding of Thomas' notion of theology. It is rooted in scripture. It is a sapiential participation in God's saving activity in the world by Christ. It is, above all else, an expression of theological life, an activity within which the theological virtues of faith, hope and love are exercised to their fullest extent.²⁸

3.1.6. Verification III: Aquinas' theology as historical and dynamic

Prior to Marie-Dominique Chenu's influential proposal, the *Summa Theologiae* was understood to be a closed, static and ahistorical construct. This was precisely its "systematic" value. Chenu's rediscovery of the dynamic *exitus-reditus* pattern in the structure of the *Summa* was but the beginning of a still fruitful study of the text. Few interpreters would challenge this basic interpretation of Thomas' thought as salvation-historical in orientation, even if they continue to quibble about how the structure reflects this orientation. Torrell, for example, argues convincingly for a series of *exitus-reditus* schemes, each giving a section of the *Summa* its own particular dynamic character.

Thomas Hibbs proposes that the *Summa Contra Gentiles* also has a dynamic and progressive character, which he characterizes as dialectical and narrative.²⁹ The dialectical character of Aristotelian logic allows Aquinas to use argumentative forms to teach the reader step by step, but this use of dialectic is governed by a narrative structure which is fundamentally scriptural. Hibbs proposes that this narrative, while it "can be categorized superficially in terms of the neo-Platonic theme of the *exitus-reditus*," is best understood as a "divine comedy" whose "point is to offer liberation from tragedy."³⁰ The Incarnation, introduced seemingly late in the work (the fourth book), is the "comic reversal": "The combination of servile and noble themes enables the divine comedy of redemption to engage directly the motifs characteristic of tragedy. Redemption is not simply restoration, but elevation beyond human desert, capacity or expectation."³¹ The *Summa Contra Gentiles* actively seeks to show forth, and thereby actually to lead into the appropriate dispositions to grasp the truth of Christian faith.

These elements of recovery are a sample of a wider set of studies that point up the dynamic and historical character of Thomas' thought. Thomas' the-

²⁷ Ibid., p. 17.

²⁸ TORRELL – op. cit., p. 5.

²⁹ THOMAS HIBBS – *Dialectic and Narrative in Aquinas*. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1995.

³⁰ Ibid., pp. 167-177.

³¹ Idem, p. 176.

ology is best understood as a historical project undertaken to teach others and effect change in the Church, which is to say as a fully engaged aesthetic-dramatic event with psychological, literary, social, theoretical and cultural dimensions rather than as an “abstract” and ahistorical construct.

3.1.7. Verification IV: Aquinas the spiritual theologian

The recent discovery, by such authors as Hadot (for Porphyry, Aristotle and Augustine), Brown and Hill (for Augustine), and Carpenter (for Bonaventure), of the unity of spiritual and doctrinal concerns in theology has been matched by a similar discovery in Aquinas studies. Hadot’s use of the term “spiritual exercise” to describe the purpose of ancient texts is particularly felicitous for our purposes: a *spiritual exercise* is both a text that is designed to engage the totality of human spiritual operations in a transformative process, and also the actual engagement of a person in this process by means of the text. This understanding connects with the usage of Bernard McGinn in his history of Western Christian mysticism, whose working definition of mysticism as “the preparation for, the consciousness of, and the reaction to what can be described as the immediate or direct presence of God”³² will allow us to situate Aquinas’ theological activity in relation to his understanding of contemplation.

It is Torrell in particular who has developed the idea that the most authentic and fullest reading of Aquinas is as a spiritual theologian whose ultimate concern is the spiritual life of his students: “La doctrine spirituelle de Thomas est une dimension implicite nécessaire de sa théologie.”³³ This is not to be understood at the expense of theology as *scientia*; rather, the commitment to the hard work of *scientia* is to be grasped as the mechanism by which spiritual transformation occurs. As Paul J. Wadell writes in his introduction to Aquinas’ ethics,

No one can meet Thomas Aquinas and remain unchanged. To read him is to prepare to be transformed, to study his theology is to risk becoming someone else. Thomas does not just want to teach us, he wants to challenge us. His hope is not only that we learn, but that we become better. Thomas wants to make us holy; that is why to begin an exploration of his vision of the moral life is to begin a journey of conversion. We cannot wander the *Summa* and remain untouched. To consider its questions is to be lured, to agree with its conclusions is to be one step closer to Thomas’ vision of our happiness.... To read him is to be opened to a life of grace and virtue leading to communion with God. To listen to him is to begin to understand why the goal of our life is to say yes to a God who is forever love....”³⁴

³² Bernard MCGINN – *The Foundations of Mysticism*. New York: Crossroad, 1995, p. xvii.

³³ TORRELL, op. cit., p. 27.

³⁴ Paul J. WADELL – *The Primacy of Love: an Introduction to the Ethics of Thomas Aquinas*. New York: Paulist Press, 1992, p. 7.

Aquinas, suggests Wadell, is a “man with designs on us.”³⁵ Like the authors of the patristic period, Thomas is concerned to form his students spiritually for the reading of scripture and the encounter with God.

3.1.8. Verification v: Recent Research on the Trivium

But how does Thomas do this? Are his efforts restricted to the use of Aristotelian *Scientia*? Already Hibbs’ work on the *Summa Contra Gentiles* suggests there is more to learn. The early decades of the twentieth century saw an explosion of patristic and medieval historical scholarship by both Catholic and secular historians, culminating – among Catholic scholars of the Middle Ages – in the work of the German and French scholars of the *ressourcement* movement, along with the creative work of the Jesuits of Lyon and the *nouvelle théologie*. Alongside this Catholic scholarship, the secular achievements of the *Annales* historians has given us a profoundly transformed understanding of what can no longer be called the “dark ages.” One of the more recent retrievals of this ongoing historical scholarship is in the area of medieval pedagogy and spiritual formation, and concerns the significance of rhetoric as the science that promotes spiritual, moral, and intellectual development.

The three disciplines of the *trivium* are grammar, dialectic, and rhetoric. Together, these three disciplines are the methodological foundation of all medieval thought. Grammar, which is a much broader term than what is intended by our present-day usage, is “the art of correct speech,” that is, the set of techniques for determining or fixing the meaning of texts: techniques of etymology, semantics, figures of speech, textual criticism, techniques for determining historical context, and so on. Grammar is the preferred mode of the patristic period, finding rich expression in the work of an Origen, an Athanasius, a Basil, a Jerome, or an Augustine.

Dialectic, “the art of true speech” concerns not only logic, but the method of the *quaestio* which proved such a flexible and fruitful instrument, as many scholars including Lonergan have noted, in the hands of medieval systematic theologians such as Abelard, Anselm, Peter Lombard, and Aquinas. It is very important to Aquinas that *sacra doctrina* be a *scientia*, “a system of thought at once deductive and empirical,” that “aims to explain states of affairs which we observe or otherwise accept... by tracing them back with syllogistic necessity to principles which provide a causal account of these states of affairs.”³⁶ But surely not everyone will understand the faith scientifically in the way Aristotle intended? Weisheipl offers us a first clue towards a solution. To call

³⁵ Ibid.

³⁶ Bruce D. MARSHALL – “*Quod scit una uetula*: Aquinas on the Nature of Theology.” In: R. van NIEUVENHOVE and J. WAWRYKOW (eds.) – *The Theology of Thomas Aquinas*. Notre Dame, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 2005, p. 7.

sacra doctrina a science is to indicate “the rationality, the reasonableness, the coherence of revelation. The alternative is to call faith irrational, absurd, and incoherent.”³⁷ Eugene Rogers gives us the definitive orientation on *sacra doctrina* as *scientia*. “A science is the more Aristotelian,” he writes, “the more it proceeds from first principles. Unitary first principles take propositional and real forms. For sacred doctrine, these first principles are respectively scripture and Christ.”³⁸ In the *Summa*, “scientific character now proceeds from first principles not on account of the [discursive] linkages they boast with a higher science, but on account of the [principal] light they shed, even if it lies beyond us.”³⁹ As Thomas shows in question one itself, it is not only propositions that can shed such principal light on other propositions, but also things: “in short, one thing can explain another. One thing can even explain another without explaining it to us.”⁴⁰ A distinct science emerges from a distinct revelation, “be it ever so worldly; or to put it in uncontroversial terms, when we have a distinct form.”⁴¹

Rhetoric, “the art of good and pleasing speech,” was ordered to human experience, and we must be careful not to limit it, as often happens today, to a shallow manipulation of tropes that make a text “pretty” or convincing despite its lying or immoral content. Contemporary advertising would be condemned by the medieval rhetorician as an evil failure of rhetoric. Ancient and medieval rhetoric concerned itself with effects of meaning at the level of experience; it was the set of techniques that evoked those images and affects that would make understanding possible for the hearer or the reader, that would create the spiritual and intellectual paths to understanding by which persons could be transformed.

Until recently, it was assumed that Aquinas, like other medieval scholastic thinkers, was mainly a dialectician, and that grammar and rhetoric were not significant in his theological method. But closer study of his scripture commentaries have revealed a master grammarian at work, which in turn has led to a renewed awareness of the significance of narrative and literary approaches to fixing meaning in his work, particularly – as Hibbs argues – in the *Summa Contra Gentiles*. Similarly, recent studies have shown him to be a very sophisticated rhetorician, particularly in his liturgical poetry but also in the *Summa Theologiae*.⁴²

³⁷ James WEISHEPL – “The Meaning of *Sacra Doctrina* in *Summa Theologiae* I, q. 1.” In: *The Thomist*, 38 (1974), p. 71.

³⁸ Eugene ROGERS – *Thomas Aquinas and Karl Barth: Sacred Doctrine and the Natural Knowledge of God*. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1995, p. 18.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 27.

⁴⁰ *Idem*, p. 23.

⁴¹ *Idem*, p. 27.

⁴² See the work of Alain Michel and Mary Carruthers on medieval rhetoric, especially Carruthers' *The Craft of Thought*; one of Alain Michel's students, Olivier-Thomas Venard, is pub-

A story from Reginald of Piperno, Thomas' *socius*, can help illustrate this point. He relates an incident connected with the composition of the literal commentary on Isaiah. At a certain point, Aquinas found himself unable to settle a point of interpretation. Reginald, who had stayed up and was in the next room, overheard Thomas talking as if to a number of other persons, their various voices emerging inchoately. Suddenly, the other voices fell silent, and Aquinas came to the door, and told Reginald to begin taking dictation, which he gave as if he were reading a page from a book. This incident can be dismissed as an instance of hagiographical exaggeration, or it can be interpreted naively as an instance of unmediated vision or visitation. If one reads it with an awareness of compositional habits, one begins to notice several interesting items in the story. First, Aquinas' use of audible speech and *murmuratio* to aid recall, a standard rhetorical practice. Next, it is possible to grasp in the plurality of voices the possibility of Aquinas actually speaking in these different voices, "acting out" the roles of his various interlocutors to stimulate recall and understanding, another common compositional practice. Mary Carruthers suggests that Aquinas' statement that his conversation had been with Peter and Paul be taken seriously, and interpreted as connected with these rhetorical practices. At no time need we deny the supernatural character of these events; nevertheless, understanding them in light of memorial practices helps us grasp them as instances of graced encounter mediated by common cultural practices.

How then did Thomas put the tools of ancient and monastic rhetoric at the service of his pedagogical concerns? How did he understand the role of practices of crafting thoughts and making memories in his intellectualist context? Aquinas' commentary on Aristotle's *De memoria et reminiscencia* reveals an Aquinas who actively retrieves the monastic tradition, but through the lens of the pseudo-Ciceronian *Rhetorica ad Herennium*. He stresses the importance of frequent meditation to assist ease of recollection: "...frequent meditation of those things which we sensed or understood preserve their memory so that one recollects well the things seen or understood. Meditation is nothing other than considering things many times as an image of things previously apprehended and not only in themselves, which mode of preserving pertains to the formality of memory."⁴³ The cause of recollecting is the order of movements by which impressions of what we apprehend are left in the soul, which order of movements is either natural, from the thing itself, or from custom, "such that one is accustomed to the fact that the second movement follows the

lishing a massive three volume study entitled *Thomas d'Aquin Poète Théologien*, and another French scholar, Gilbert Narcisse, has produced *Les Raisons de Dieu*, a study of *convenientia* as an argument form in Aquinas. See also my own doctoral dissertation *Embracing Wisdom: The Spiritual Pedagogy of Thomas Aquinas* soon – I hope! – to be published.

⁴³ AQUINAS – *Sentencia libri de memoria et reminiscencia*, lectio 3, section 348.

first in the majority of instances.”⁴⁴ This ordered movement forms a *ductus* through the material one retains; a proper *ductus* is the result of performing four key tasks: reducing to some order what one wishes to retain; applying the mind profoundly and intently – with *sollicitudo* – to these things; frequently meditating on them in their proper order; always beginning to recollect from the starting point.⁴⁵ This starting point ought to be more universal, “that from which one is wont to be moved to divers things.”⁴⁶

The order which Thomas makes so much of is, in the case of the *Summa*, the *ordo doctrinae*, and this involves a particular *ductus* that governs the literary composition of the text. Olivier-Thomas Venard has recently published a careful study of the poetics of the *Summa*, the art that governed its composition, thus re-establishing the link between the intellectualist and memorial dimensions of the text.

Thomas chooses a very specific poetics for the text of the *Summa*: the clarity, transparency and sparseness of the text promote an adequation of the form of the text to the matter of the divine mysteries, and thus of the mind to the mysteries through the instrumentality of the text. This personal choice corresponds to Thomas’ act of faith: because God has chosen to speak the language of human beings, a discourse on God is now possible, which ought to be shaped by God’s initial speech.

3.1.9. Lonergan’s Fundamental Interpretive Stance towards Aquinas

The picture that emerges from recent Aquinas scholarship is of a theologian concerned with understanding the *oikonomia* revealed in Scripture who seeks to promote the intellectual, moral and spiritual transformation of his students by using the tools of all three realms of the *trivium*. Aquinas is able to fulfill all three basic responsibilities of the *magister in sacra pagina* with ease and delight: *lectio* on the sacred page, which brought grammar to the fore though not at the expense of the other two; *disputatio* in the classroom and in public, to determine the truth behind the conflict of authorities by means of dialectic; and *predicatio*, the fruit of all *sacra doctrina*, where the meaning determined in *lectio* and the understanding developed by means of the *quaestio* found its expression in speech that sought to participate in the transformation that God was working by grace in the Church and the world.

This renewed understanding would seem to verify Lonergan’s interpretive stance towards Aquinas, which gave pride of place to Aquinas’ theological concerns and understood Aquinas’ use of Aristotelian philosophy as a meth-

⁴⁴ Ibid., lectio 5, section 360.

⁴⁵ Idem, section 371.

⁴⁶ Idem, lectio 6, section 379.

odological appropriation at the service of the Gospel. Lonergan was explicit on a number of occasions about his awareness of Aquinas' use of dialectic, but his interpretive stance also directed his attention – though he does not thematize this – to the results of Aquinas' use of grammar. It also allowed him to intuit the importance of inner experience in Thomas' theology, as we saw in our study of *Verbum*. This pointed him in the direction of Thomas' use of rhetoric.⁴⁷ Contemporary Thomas research then, allows us to thematize and amplify Lonergan's initial relation to Aquinas more fully. We can define the first moment of Lonergan's relation to Aquinas as the development of an upper blade sensitive to Aquinas' sophistication in the deployment of the whole *trivium* in the practice of theology.

3.3. The Second Moment: Using the Upper Blade

The second moment in the relation between Lonergan and Aquinas emerges from the first in the way that concrete performance emerges from theoretical understanding, or application from general principle. It simply consists in the ongoing use of the upper blade on the lower blade provided by actual difficulties in understanding Aquinas. This moment includes the very fruitful interpretations contained in *Grace and Freedom* and *Verbum*, and continues through a whole series of articles from the 1940's onwards. Of the articles contained in *Collection*, one might single out "On God and Secondary Causes," "The Natural Desire to See God," "Theology and Understanding," and "Isomorphism of Thomist and Scientific Thought." But this moment also includes the published texts for his theology courses: *De Constitutione Christi*, *De Deo Trino*, *De Verbo Incarnato*, among others.

In the process of preparing this essay, I was reminded of just how extensive this body of work is – by my very rough count, there are 21 major and minor works that either directly comment on Aquinas or make significant use of Aquinas' theological insights – and how significant a portion of Lonergan's scholarly output it represents. Taken as a whole, this body of work makes of Lonergan an important twentieth-century commentator on Aquinas. It also gives the lie to any notion that reading Aquinas in light of Lonergan introduces distortions or misinterpretations in our understanding of Thomas' theology. Lonergan is not engaged in a selective or tendentious reading of the texts. He does not construct elaborate secondary arguments to defend his reading of Aquinas, nor does he multiply entities and concepts to justify his position. The interpretations stand on their own terms; one is only required to verify them in the text and make one's own judgment about their adequacy.

⁴⁷ I believe that it is the work of Robert Doran on psychic conversion, which Lonergan endorsed, which makes explicit the retrieval and transposition of Aquinas' use of rhetoric as a method of spiritual, moral and intellectual transformation.

A very good example of this second moment can be found in *De Verbo Incarnato*, though *De Deo Trino*'s retrieval of the psychological analogy or *De Constitutione Christi*'s sorting out of the analogy between the ontological and psychological constitution of Christ could also serve. In one of the later theses of *De Verbo Incarnato*, Lonergan is presenting Thomas' doctrine that the incarnate Word enjoyed the beatific vision before the events of the resurrection. Thomas' account is telegraphic, stating in particular that in order to allow for Christ to have a genuine acquired knowledge (like the rest of us – this was a revolutionary innovation on the part of Aquinas), the gift of beatific knowing had to be “held at the apex of the soul.” This short text is, to say the least, difficult to interpret properly. Lonergan's solution, which he grounds in his interpretation of Aquinas' *intelligere* (upper blade), is of supreme elegance and simplicity: because beatific knowing is infused by grace without mediation by ordinary experience, it is of itself ineffable. The person who experiences it does not have experiential correlates to express it, even to him or her self. Such a person is like the mystic who has been lifted out of the world of ordinary experience and enjoyed immediate communion with God. Upon returning to self, the mystic cannot say what he or she now knows, though the knowledge is genuine and transformative of both the person and his or her horizon of knowing. The rest of that person's life is spent acquiring the ordinary experience that will enable some articulation of what one now knows ineffably; one's life project is to move from ineffable to effable knowing. In the case of Christ, the gift of beatific knowing is an ineffable knowing born of God's love that orients his whole life. The “apex of the soul” is the fullness of being-in-love (to borrow a later articulation of Lonergan's) as a stable disposition that produces a knowing that orients Christ's whole life, including his acquisition of knowledge from ordinary experiences.

3.4. The Third Moment: Transposing Aquinas in *Insight*

The third moment, like the second, emerges from the first moment of Lonergan's basic interpretive stance as concrete performance emerges from theoretical understanding. But where the second moment consists of applying the upper blade to the task of actually interpreting Aquinas, the third moment consists of applying that same upper blade to the task of transposing Thomist insights and methodology for a new audience.

Transposition is Lonergan's own term for this activity, and we must understand what it means. Transposition is a musical term: when a musician transposes a melody or other piece of music, she is reproducing it in a new musical key. The task is to preserve the musical shape, harmonies and resonances using the different musical relationships available in the new key. It is not simply a question of sounding “higher” or “lower”; the task requires under-

standing the new musical terms and relations that define the new key. When Lonergan speaks of transposing Aquinas, he means to reproduce the shape, harmonies and resonances that define Aquinas' achievement, using the methodological tools and insights of our own day. Like Aquinas, Lonergan will both appropriate and correct the tools of his day, as he does for himself (and for us) what Aquinas did with the tools of the *trivium*. Lonergan's Thomism here is mainly *performative*, though in key places in *Insight* he consciously retrieves Aquinas' content.

This, I would propose, is the best way to understand *Insight* in relation to the work of Aquinas. In this work, Lonergan is speaking in his own voice and developing his own insights, and so there is more going forward than just Thomist insights; nevertheless, there is a lot of Thomas in the book. In the space provided here, I will address the most controversial issue for many Thomists, Lonergan's appropriation of the turn to the subject as a way of critically grounding a Thomist metaphysics.

Few people question the fact that there are significant Thomist elements in *Insight*: the isomorphism of knowing and being, the empirical definition of being, the root of human knowing in identity, the tripartite metaphysics of potency, form and act are all key structures central to the work. The most common objection to *Insight* is methodological, namely that the turn to the subject is irretrievably modern and ultimately Kantian, and necessarily so.⁴⁸ But Lonergan's turn to the subject is rooted in his understanding of the centrality of inner experience in Augustine, Aristotle and Aquinas, which he gained in the *Verbum* studies.

Recent research in mystical theology shows that not all anthropological turns are Kantian: such early modern mystics as Francis de Sales, John of the Cross, Teresa of Avila, and Ignatius of Loyola all propose Christian versions of the turn to the subject. Gordon Rixon and Robert Doran, in recent studies, have shown Lonergan's intellectual debt to the Ignatian spirituality of his Jesuit formation. Rixon in particular shows the significant link between Lonergan's turn to the subject and the Ignatian examen of consciousness.⁴⁹

The issue is whether, as MacIntyre seems to suggest, every instance of the turn to the subject constitutes an uncritical acceptance of Kantian definitions of epistemological problems. Aside from the difficulty of maintaining

⁴⁸ See, for example, Alasdair MACINTYRE – *The Maritain Notebook* 3.2 [1995], which calls transcendental Thomism an unfortunate “hybrid”, and lumps together a whole series of Thomists who have very different understandings of the turn to the subject. Lonergan himself did not use the term “transcendental method” for very long; he much preferred to call his approach in the first few chapters of *Insight* a “generalized empirical method.”

⁴⁹ See Gordon RIXON – “Bernard Lonergan and Mysticism.” In: *Theological Studies*. 62 (2001), pp. 479-497. Of particular importance here is footnote 52 on page 492, which records Lonergan's developing understanding of his own theological appropriation of the Ignatian examen.

this position on historical grounds – Francis de Sales and the other mystics predate Kant – there is the possibility of showing that Lonergan's own turn to the subject is not to be understood along the same lines as those of other transcendental thinkers. Giovanni Sala has shown in a definitive way the significant differences between Kant and Lonergan on this issue.⁵⁰ We also have Lonergan's own critical appreciation of the *Metaphysics* of Emerich Coreth, in the English translation by Joseph Donceel. Here Lonergan makes a conscious and explicit refusal of the Kantian option:

It is to be noted that the operative moment in Fr. Coreth's use of transcendental method cannot occur in a Kantian context. For that operative moment lies in a contradiction not between content and content but between content and performance; but a Kantian context... does not envisage performances. Thus, there is no explicit contradiction in the content of the statement, We are under an illusion when we claim to know what really is. On the other hand, there is an explicit contradiction in the reflective statement: I am stating what really and truly is so when I state that we are under an illusion whenever we claim to know what really and truly is so. However, the content of the explicitly contradictory statement adds to the content of the first what is found implicitly in the first, not as content, but as performance.... [While] Kant envisages an *Ich denke* (I think) as a formal condition of the possibility of objective contents being thought, still he cannot find room for a concrete reality intelligently asking and rationally answering questions...⁵¹

Lonergan understands his own turn to the subject – along with Coreth's – as an empirical turn in opposition precisely to Kant's abstract and formal transcendental turn. He applies the cognitional operations of experience, insight and judgment – themselves transpositions of Augustinian and Thomist *memoria* and *verbum* – to the self-reflection that leads one to affirm oneself as a knower. Thus the first nine chapters of *Insight* must be understood as an application of transposed categories appropriated (in *Verbum*) from Thomist psychology to the question of the turn to the subject. By preserving in particular the Thomist "knowing through identity", Lonergan ensures that his turn to the subject does not give rise to a Cartesian or Kantian "bridge problem:" the subject I turn to is myself operating, and the understanding I have is from the phantasm that emerges from my own experience of myself operating. In all this, interestingly enough and by way of conclusion, Lonergan's efforts are remarkably parallel to those of Francis de Sales in the *Treatise on the Love of God*.

⁵⁰ Giovanni SALA – *Lonergan and Kant: Five Essays on Human Knowledge*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1994.

⁵¹ Bernard LONERGAN – "Metaphysics as Horizon." In: Emerich CORETH – *Metaphysics*. New York: Seabury Press, 1973, pp. 204-205.

3.5. The Fourth Moment: A Reflective Call for a Renewed Thomism

The fourth moment emerges from the second and third moments as self-understanding emerges from operating in the world. The labour of understanding and interpreting Aquinas over a period of eleven years, and the process of writing *Insight* and subsequently lecturing on it are the conditions of possibility of the emergence of the fourth moment. What *Insight* adds to the interpretation of Aquinas is the set of operations necessary to transpose the old and augment and perfect it with the new, the full range of operations required by Lonergan's acceptance of Leo XIII's *vetera novis augere et perficere* as his personal motto.

This moment is captured in two texts: the first, a lecture given in 1968 and published in *Second Collection*, is entitled "The Future of Thomism;" the second, a lecture given in 1974 in Chicago and published in *A Third Collection*, is entitled "Aquinas Today: Tradition and Innovation." Much of "Aquinas Today" echoes the fuller treatment contained in "The Future of Thomism," so I will mainly concentrate on this first essay.

In "The Future of Thomism," Lonergan proceeds in three basic steps: first, he gives an account of Aquinas' practice of theology in its own context; then, he reviews the characteristics of what he calls classical Thomism; finally, he articulates his program for what he calls a "Thomism for tomorrow". The whole lecture is a making explicit of his own practices in interpreting, transposing and developing Aquinas' theology. He re-expresses the key elements of his upper blade, and states his personal conviction that "a mature Catholic theology of the twentieth century will not ignore [Aquinas]; it will learn very, very much from him; and it will be aware of its debt to him..."⁵² What better description can there be of Lonergan's own work in interpreting Aquinas? The third part of the lecture proposes a set of five transpositions which a renewed Thomism will perform: from logic to method; from an Aristotelian to a modern conception of science; from soul to subject; from human nature to human history; and from first principles to transcendental method.⁵³ Again, is this not a description of Lonergan's own labours in writing *Insight*?

4. Conclusion: A Renewal in Thomas Studies

Lonergan's complex relation to Aquinas, as we have just seen, can be understood as an emergent series of four moments. The first moment entails the development of an upper blade sensitive enough to direct Lonergan's attention to all three sets of methods deployed by Aquinas from the trivium: grammatical, dialectical and rhetorical. The second moment, the actual use

⁵² "The Future of Thomism." In: *Second Collection*, p. 49.

⁵³ Idem, pp. 48-52.

of the upper blade, emerges from the first moment as application and performance from theoretical understanding. The third moment also emerges from the first as performance from theoretical understanding, but consists in using the upper blade to govern transpositions of Thomas' thought for today. The fourth moment emerges from the second and third as self-understanding from performance.

The fourth moment constitutes a program of renewal for theology that learns from Thomas, but it is also the condition for the emergence of a renewal in Thomas studies proper. This renewal in Thomas studies depends not just on the program outlined in "The Future of Thomism," but adds to it the whole range of development in Lonergan's own thought on history, theology and method. These are the developments contained in *Method in Theology*, along with a few late essays, where Lonergan develops his understanding of religion and of an empirical/anthropological notion of culture, along with his account of the scale of values and his complex theory of meaning.⁵⁴ To these key elements we can add Bob Doran's development of some of them. At the same time, historical studies of the medieval university in particular and the medieval period in general have multiplied, filling out the details available to Lonergan.

The last twenty years have seen a multiplication of historical studies of Thomas, though with hit-and-miss notions of history and historical method. In some cases, the greater knowledge we have of the medieval period and the medieval university allows us to verify Lonergan's reading of Aquinas from independent sources. In other cases, we can move beyond Lonergan's reading by honing or extending his upper blade, particularly in terms of a greater understanding of medieval rhetoric, and of the trivium in general, as we have begun to do here. This enables us to achieve a much more complete grasp of Aquinas' theology as a response of soteriological constitutive meaning to shifts in the dialectic of culture from cosmological to anthropological constitutive meaning. A wider range of Aquinas' writings, including his correspondence and his social and cultural tracts, becomes relevant to understanding his theology. In other words, our understanding of Aquinas becomes more concrete, which in turn makes more nuanced transpositions possible.⁵⁵ Finally, the fourth moment contributes to a historically-conscious enterprise of Thomas studies in general, offering other scholars a set of sophisticated methodological reflections and tools that can correct mistaken notions of history and augment their repertoire of approaches to the text.

⁵⁴ Lonergan's repeated use of Romans 5:5 in *Method* and subsequent articles and lectures should also be noted here as a further appropriation of Thomas.

⁵⁵ See my paper "Religion and Culture in Aquinas," presented last fall at the Boston College Lonergan Symposium; see also my doctoral dissertation.